

DEADLINES, NOT LIFELINES

written by

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FADE IN:

INT. MEDICAL PLAZA -- PARKING STRUCTURE -- MORNING

A parked Buick, twenty years old, immaculate. Behind the wheel: JONATHAN LOFT, 44 -- sharp-eyed, softening everywhere else, dressed like a man who irons his casual clothes. He is not getting out of the car.

He checks the dashboard clock: 9:41. Appointment's at 10:00.

He looks at the medical building through the windshield the way infantry looks at a beach.

On the passenger seat: a manila folder, labeled in block print -- "PHYSICAL -- TALKING POINTS." Inside, we glimpse: a printed list of symptoms he does not have, pre-denied. A family history chart. A single index card that reads, underlined twice: "DO NOT ACCEPT THE WORD 'LIFESTYLE.'"

He rehearses, out loud, to the rearview mirror:

JONATHAN

"Actually, doctor, the literature on BMI is famously contested."

(beat; adjusting tone;
softer, more amused, a man
of the world)

"Actually -- the literature on BMI is famously contested."

(beat; discarding both; new
approach, disarming,
collegial)

"Look, we both know BMI was
invented by an astronomer."

He nods. That's the one. He checks the clock: 9:52. He breathes like a free diver.

He gets out of the car.

INT. DR. OYELARAN'S OFFICE -- EXAM ROOM -- LATER

Jonathan sits on the exam table, shirt back on,
mid-campaign. DR. OYELARAN, 50s, unhurried, reads the
chart with the calm of a woman who has never once been
argued out of a number.

JONATHAN

-- and we both know BMI was
invented by an astronomer, so --

DR. OYELARAN

(not looking up)
Your blood pressure is 148 over
94.

JONATHAN

Which -- white coat syndrome.
Documented phenomenon. You take
it here, in the, frankly,
adversarial context of --

DR. OYELARAN

Your A1C is 6.3. That's
prediabetic.

JONATHAN

"Pre." Prefix meaning "not yet."
I'd argue "pre" anything
describes every living person --

DR. OYELARAN

(looking up now; pleasant;
terminal)
Mr. Loft. How did your
grandfather die?

Silence. The one question that wasn't in the folder.

JONATHAN

(quietly; the wind gone)
Lungs. He smoked. I don't smoke.
I've never -- not once, not one
cigarette.

DR. OYELARAN
(writing; mild; the thesis
of the film in one line
she'd never call a thesis)
Nobody picks their grandfather's
exact door. They just pick a
door.

She tears off a lab slip. Holds it out.

DR. OYELARAN (CONT'D)
Bloodwork in three months. Walk
thirty minutes a day. It's not
dramatic. That's what's hard
about it for people like you --
there's nothing to fight.

Jonathan takes the slip like a subpoena.

INT. MEDICAL PLAZA -- PARKING STRUCTURE -- MINUTES LATER

Jonathan sits back in the Buick. Stares ahead. The whole
visit: eleven minutes.

He takes out his phone and dials. It rings once --

MARCO (V.O.)
(answering; sunny; mouth
full)
How'd the trial go? Did they
convict?

JONATHAN
(already narrating; the
debrief he came for)
She weaponized my grandfather in
the first five minutes. FIRST
five. That's not medicine, that's
-- there's a word for that --

MARCO (V.O.)
"Insight"?

JONATHAN

Ambush. The word is ambush.

EXT./INT. STARDUST DINER -- VAN NUYS -- DAY

A real one -- googie roofline, forty years of grease in the walls, a mini-jukebox coin console at every booth. Jonathan slides into a window booth where MARCO REYES, 41, is already established: silk camp shirt, iced coffee, tarot app open on his phone. Easygoing the way a hammock is easygoing -- it looks effortless and it's actually engineering.

Overhead, the house speakers play doo-wop, mid-fi and eternal.

MARCO

(not looking up from the
tarot app)

Before you sit down: is this a
lunch or a deposition?

JONATHAN

(sitting)

She gave me a lab slip. Three
months. It's basically a summons
--

MARCO

Uh-huh. I pulled a card for you
this morning. The Tower.

(he shows the phone; a
tower, on fire, people
leaping)

Which sounds bad, but it's
actually about necessary
collapse. Old structures. Boom.
Room for new ones.

JONATHAN

It's a picture of people falling
out of a burning building, Marco.

MARCO

It's about CHANGE.

JONATHAN

That is what falling out of a
burning building is. It's a
change.

The WAITRESS arrives -- VAL, 60s, been here since the
Carter administration.

VAL

The usual disaster?

JONATHAN

(with dignity)

Patty melt. Extra Thousand
Island. Onion rings instead of --

MARCO

(to Val)

He's prediabetic as of this
morning.

VAL

(writing; unmoved)

Rings it is.

She goes. Marco looks at Jonathan. Jonathan looks at the
table.

MARCO

"Pre" means not yet, right?
You've got that speech loaded.

JONATHAN

It's not a speech.

MARCO

It's a speech. You've got a
speech for the doctor, a speech
for the parking guy, a speech for

the self-checkout when it accuses
you of the unexpected item --

Overhead, the song changes -- another doo-wop tune,
swaying, saxophone.

MARCO (CONT'D)

(gesturing at the ceiling
with his straw; the ancient
needle, lovingly inserted)
See, and this. How do you TELL
these apart? It's all diner
music. Every one of these songs
is the same song. Guy misses
girl, doo-wop doo-wop, saxophone,
done.

JONATHAN

(instantly; no hesitation; a
reflex deeper than pain)
"In the Still of the Night." The
Five Satins. Recorded in 1956 in
the basement of a Catholic church
in New Haven -- St. Bernadette's
-- because they couldn't afford a
studio. That's a church basement
you're hearing. That echo is
Jesus's actual house. Peaked at
number three R&B, twenty-four pop
--

MARCO

(to Val, passing with
coffee)
I call it diner music one time --

JONATHAN

Every time. You do it every time,
and every time you're wrong,
because --

(leaning in; this matters to
him in a way that has
nothing to do with music and

everything to do with a man
not present)

-- they are not the same song.
That's the whole -- listen to the
bass singer. Under everything. He
never gets the melody, he never
gets the girl, he's just down
there going "doo-doo-doo,"
holding the entire thing up,
completely unthanked --

MARCO

(watching him; gently; the
trap already sprung)
Huh. Wonder what that reminds me
of.

JONATHAN

(beat)
Don't do the thing where the
tarot app does psychology.

MARCO

That wasn't the app. That was me.

Val delivers the patty melt. Jonathan eats. On the ceiling
speaker, the Five Satins hold the note. The bass singer
goes doo-doo-doo, holding the entire thing up, completely
unthanked.

INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- LIVING ROOM -- EVENING

A 1961 ranch house in Van Nuys, frozen at approximately
1974. Wood paneling. A ZENITH CONSOLE STEREO the size of a
casket, waxed to a shine. Shelf after shelf after shelf of
RECORDS -- thousands, spines ordered by a system only two
men ever understood, one of them deceased.

On the wall: a framed photo of EARL LOFT, 70s in the
photo, cigarette in hand like it grew there, squinting
into some backyard sun, mid-laugh at something forever
off-camera.

Jonathan comes in, sets his keys in a dish that was
Earl's, drops the lab slip on a stack of unopened mail --

and we see the stack: weeks deep. Something official-looking, from "GREENE & ASSOCIATES, PROBATE," peeks out mid-pile, unopened. The film notices. Jonathan doesn't.

He thumbs the console open. Slides a 45 from a paper sleeve, handling it like a relic, which it is. Sets it down. Needle in.

The song blooms into the room -- horns, a shuffle, 1962 from wall to wall.

Jonathan sits in the recliner. Earl's recliner -- his body finds the dent Earl's body left. He closes his eyes.

For a moment -- one whole verse -- the man is actually at rest. The house holds him like the recliner does: a dead man's shape, kept warm.

Then, as the song leans toward its final chorus, toward the fade --

Jonathan gets up, crosses, and LIFTS THE NEEDLE. Mid-phrase. Silence slams in.

He sleeves the 45 and files it, precise, spine-perfect. As he does:

JONATHAN

(to Earl's photo;
conversational; the tone of
a long-running argument)

The fade-out is a cop-out. You
always said that. A real song
should know how to leave.

Earl's photo squints into its permanent sunshine and declines, as ever, to confirm the quote.

Jonathan turns off the lamp. In the dark, the house ticks and settles around him -- an estate, unsettled, both meanings, and only one of them knows it yet.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. THE KING'S ARMS -- BAR -- NIGHT

A fake-Tudor sports bar, Van Nuys Boulevard. Tuesday night: PUB QUIZ. Jonathan stands at a mic with laminated question cards, running the room like a game show host who believes the format is beneath him and the audience is beneath the format.

JONATHAN

(into mic)

Round four, question six. In 1961, this session drummer played on -- and I want to stress that your phones are visible to me, Table Nine, this is not Guantanamo but I have eyes --

The crowd: six tables of regulars. At one, PRIYA, 38, ER nurse, sharp, here every Tuesday, heckles with love:

PRIYA

Just read the question, Loft!

JONATHAN

The question has CONTEXT, Priya. Without context it's just trivia.

PRIYA

It IS trivia! That's the night! Trivia night!

JONATHAN

(a wounded pause; then, to the room, quietly devastating himself)

It doesn't have to be.

He reads the question. The room bends to answer sheets. And for a second, watch Jonathan at the mic, surveying it: a man with a nine-lane mind, hosting trivia in a fake-Tudor bar on a Tuesday, eleven years running -- and the film lets us feel, under the laminate, how this

happened one completely reasonable decision at a time.

INT. THE KING'S ARMS -- BAR -- LATER

Quiz over. Jonathan packs cards into a shoebox -- and the shoebox is labeled, and the labels have sub-labels. Priya, coat on, pauses on her way out.

PRIYA

My cousin runs a podcast network.
Music history stuff. I told him
about you -- the church basement
thing, the session drummer thing.
He said send him a demo. Ten
minutes. Just you, talking, like
you do.

She sets a business card on the shoebox.

JONATHAN

(looking at the card; and
here it is, the mechanism,
arriving smooth as a valet)
Podcasts are saturated. The
music-history vertical especially
-- there's four majors and
they've got institutional
archives, licensing budgets, I'd
be a guy in a house. And the
licensing alone, you can't even
PLAY the songs, you have to talk
around them, which is a
fundamentally compromised --

PRIYA

(cutting through; kind;
done)
Jonathan. It's ten minutes into a
phone.

JONATHAN

(beat)
I'll look at the space.

PRIYA
(going; over her shoulder;
the scene's kill shot,
thrown away)
You've been looking at the space
since I met you. One of these
days the space closes.

The door swings shut behind her. Jonathan stands with the card in his hand. Then he files it -- precisely -- in the shoebox, under a sub-label. Where great ideas go to be organized.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. SEPULVEDA BOULEVARD -- DAY

The Buick, dusty for the first time in the film -- two weeks of pollen and one act of God via pigeon. Jonathan drives. Ahead, on the right: SUNSHINE EXPRESS CAR WASH. A tunnel wash. Attendants in red shirts. Vacuums. A menu board.

Jonathan pulls past it. Doesn't turn in. Watches it in the side mirror like a bank he's casing.

INT. BUICK -- MOVING -- CONTINUOUS

Around the block. Jonathan at the wheel, running it down. The variables, in INSERT SHOTS as his eyes move:

-- THE MENU BOARD: four packages. Bronze. Silver. Gold. Platinum. The gap between Silver (\$22) and Gold (\$34) is where they get you. Undercarriage flush: real, or theater?

-- THE TIP JAR: cash only? There's a Venmo QR code taped to it now. New development. Changes everything.

-- THE HAND-DRY CREW at the exit: two men with towels. You're in neutral, rolling -- window down or up? Down says approachable, invites the upsell recap. Up says fortress, and then the tip exchange happens through GLASS, like a

prison visit.

JONATHAN

(alone; aloud; grim)

Window down. Tip ready.

Pre-folded. No wallet fumbling at
the exit -- you fumble the
wallet, you're theirs.

He pre-folds three singles and clips them to the visor
like a magazine into a rifle.

He circles back around. Signals. Turns in.

**EXT. SUNSHINE EXPRESS CAR WASH -- ENTRANCE LANE --
CONTINUOUS**

An ATTENDANT, 19, approaches the window, menu-brochure
out. Jonathan lowers the window exactly four inches.

ATTENDANT

Morning! So today we've got a
special on the Platinum, it's --

JONATHAN

(rehearsed at dawn; deployed
at last)

Silver. Just the Silver. I know
about the undercarriage flush and
I've made my peace.

ATTENDANT

(blinking; writing)
...Silver. You got it.

The attendant chalks the windshield and waves him forward.
That's it. That's the whole confrontation. Months of it,
in Jonathan's head -- resolved in nine seconds by a
teenager thinking about lunch.

INT. BUICK -- INSIDE THE WASH TUNNEL -- CONTINUOUS

Darkness. Then the strips hit -- WHUMP -- soap arcing
across the glass in slow motion, blue and pink foam

crawling the windshield, the great cloth tentacles slapping over the roof. The score swells. Light strobes through foam.

And Jonathan, hands off the wheel, in the belly of the machine --

-- exhales.

Look at him: lit by wash-light, water hammering, and it's the second-most-peaceful we have ever seen this man, because for ninety seconds he is inside a process he cannot control, steer, exit, or improve, and every one of his nine lanes has nothing to do. The machine does not require his input. It's the recliner with jets.

The dryers ROAR. Daylight blooms at the tunnel mouth like a verdict.

EXT. SUNSHINE EXPRESS -- EXIT -- CONTINUOUS

The hand-dry crew descends, towels snapping. Jonathan rolls the window down -- fully -- takes the pre-folded bills off the visor, and hands them over with a nod he has practiced in the shower.

HAND-DRY GUY

Have a good one, boss.

JONATHAN

(pulling out; to himself;
quietly; the after-action
report)

Clean exit.

The Buick gleams onto Sepulveda. Behind it, the car wash returns to being a car wash, having at no point been anything else.

INT. MARCO'S APARTMENT -- NORTH HOLLYWOOD -- DAY

A one-bedroom overwhelmed by ambition: a rented garment rack, a sewing machine mid-project, fabric bolts leaned in corners like guests at a party. On the wall, a mood board -- vintage menswear, saints' medallions, zodiac charts, Polaroids.

Marco, reading glasses on -- we've never seen the glasses; the glasses mean this is real -- lays a LOOKBOOK on the kitchen table in front of Jonathan. Homemade. Card stock. Hand-bound.

On the cover: "SECOND SIGN -- a menswear line by Marco Reyes."

MARCO

(and all the hammock is gone
from his voice; this is the
un-easy Marco, the one
nobody gets to see)

Okay. So. Eight pieces. Camp
shirts, two jackets, the
medallion print's the anchor --
everything's cut generous because
clothes should forgive you,
that's the whole -- that's kind
of the thesis, clothes that
forgive you --

(flipping pages; talking
faster; vulnerability making
him narrate like his cousin)

-- there's a vendor market
downtown, they do an incubator
thing, I got a callback, which --
four hundred applied, they took
sixty to the callback round, so.

(he stops himself; closes
the book; slides it across;
bare)

Anyway. You're the smartest
person I know. Tell me what you
think.

HOLD on that sentence, because it is a man handing his
cousin a loaded gun and asking him to check the sights.

Jonathan opens the lookbook.

And the film goes quiet, and we watch him read, page by
page, and we can see the machine spin up behind his eyes
-- the same nine lanes that killed the podcast in one
breath, the beautiful merciless scanner -- finding every
seam, every margin, every soft spot. Finding the flaws the

way it always finds the flaws: instantly, thoroughly, and without being asked which target it's pointed at.

Jonathan closes the book.

JONATHAN

Honestly?

MARCO

(a beat; he almost says no;
he doesn't)

Honestly.

JONATHAN

(and it comes out level,
precise, unhurried -- not
cruel in tone, which is what
makes it unforgivable in
content)

The margins don't work. You're hand-finishing eight-piece runs, which caps you at maybe twenty units a month, and at your price point that's a hobby with a logo. The medallion print reads as novelty -- novelty gets one season, then you're the guy who did the saint shirts. The incubator market takes thirty percent and their foot traffic is tourists who photograph clothes and buy churros. You have no size run above XL, which cuts out half the men who'd actually love a shirt that quote-unquote forgives them. And the name -- "Second Sign" -- nobody knows what it means without your tarot app, and a brand you have to explain is a brand that's already losing.

(beat)

You asked.

Silence.

Marco takes off the reading glasses. Folds them. It takes him a moment because his hands want to do something else.

MARCO

(quietly)

Yeah. I asked.

JONATHAN

(mistaking the quiet for
absorption; leaning in,
warming to it, actually
trying to HELP now, which is
the tragedy)

It's fixable. Some of it. If you
cut the run to four pieces and
license the print instead of --

MARCO

Jonathan.

JONATHAN

-- what?

MARCO

(no blowup; no tears; he
just stands and starts, very
carefully, straightening the
fabric bolts, not looking at
him)

You know what's funny? I've
watched you do that to yourself
for twenty years. The podcast.
The record guide you never wrote.
The girl in Burbank. Every single
time, I watched you take the
beautiful thing out back and
shoot it before it could
embarrass you. And I always
thought -- god, that's so sad, he
only does that because he's
scared.

(he turns; and he's not
crying; he's worse than
crying; he's done)
You're not scared of my line,
cuz. Nothing in that book can
hurt YOU. You just heard
something starting and you
reached for the gun. It's a
reflex now. It doesn't even check
whose idea it's pointed at.

JONATHAN

Marco, I was answering the
question --

MARCO

(gathering the lookbook off
the table; gently, like
picking up a child that
someone dropped)
Sixty callbacks out of four
hundred.

(beat)

You didn't ask one question, you
know that? Everything you said --
and it was smart, it's always
smart, some of it's even right --
there wasn't one question in it.
"Who's it for?" "What's it feel
like to wear one?" Nothing. You
did a demolition inspection on a
house nobody's finished building
and you called it honesty.

He opens the apartment door. Stands beside it. The
politest ejection in cinema history.

MARCO (CONT'D)

I gotta finish a jacket.

JONATHAN

(standing; at the door; one
last unit of pure Jonathan,

unable to stop the machine
even now)
The shoulder seams on the sample
were actually --

MARCO
(closing the door; final;
soft)
Goodnight, Jonathan.

The door clicks. Jonathan stands in the hallway of a North Hollywood walk-up, alone with the best diagnostic mind in the family and no remaining patients.

EXT. NORTH HOLLYWOOD STREET -- NIGHT

Jonathan walks to the Buick. Gets in. Sits.

He takes out his phone. Pulls up MARCO in the messages.
Types: "The medallion print IS strong, I should have led
with"

Deletes it.

Types: "You asked for honest"

Deletes it.

Types nothing. Puts the phone in the cupholder
screen-down, in its little assigned spot, and drives home
with the radio off.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- KITCHEN -- MORNING

Jonathan, in Earl's old robe, makes coffee in a percolator
older than he is. The unopened mail stack has migrated to
the kitchen table, where it can be ignored at closer
range.

The doorbell rings. Then knocks -- the brisk, double-tap
knock of family with an agenda.

INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- LIVING ROOM -- CONTINUOUS

AUNT REGINA, 68 -- Earl's daughter, Jonathan's aunt -- comes in mid-sentence, the way she enters all rooms. Behind her, apologetic by nature: her husband GERRY, 70, in an enormous knee brace.

REGINA

-- because you don't answer mail,
Johnny, so now it's a house call,
and Gerry's knee is a house
call's worth of complaining, so
we'll keep it short.

She stops in the living room. Looks around at it -- the paneling, the console, the records, the museum of her own father, kept climate-controlled by her nephew for eleven years.

REGINA (CONT'D)

(a breath; then, plainly,
kindly, and with no exit
built into the sentence)
We sold the house, honey. Escrow
closed yesterday. The buyers take
possession in sixty days.

Silence. The percolator burbles in the kitchen like something trying to change the subject.

JONATHAN

(very still)
You -- the house isn't on the
market.

REGINA

It was never going to be "on the
market." Kwan next door made an
offer two years ago and I finally
said yes. Cash. No contingencies.
(beat; gentler)
Gerry's knee is titanium now,
Johnny. The other one's next.

We're seventy. The house is the retirement. It was always going to be the retirement -- Dad set it up that way, it's in the letters you don't open.

Jonathan looks at the mail stack through the kitchen doorway. GREENE & ASSOCIATES, PROBATE. Weeks deep.

JONATHAN

(reaching; the machine spinning up, hunting for the flaw in it, the angle, the exit -- and finding, for the first time in his adult life, a wall with no doors in it)

Sixty days is -- there are tenant protections, notice periods, the -- I'm technically a --

REGINA

You're not a tenant, honey. You're family who stayed. There's no lease. There was never a lease. There was Dad saying "let the kid land on his feet," and that was eleven years ago.

(she sits on the arm of the sofa; the closest she'll come to sentiment)

Nobody's angry. You kept it beautiful. He'd have liked how you kept it.

(beat)

But it's sixty days, and it's real, and I need you to hear the "real" part, because I know how you do. This isn't the doctor's office. There's no arguing with escrow. Escrow doesn't care about context.

GERRY

(from the doorway; helpful)
Escrow's like weather.

REGINA

(standing; patting
Jonathan's cheek once, brisk
and loving)

The records are yours -- he wrote
that down, it's the one thing he
wrote down. "The records go to
Johnny." Everything else goes in
the estate sale.

(at the door; final
logistics; mercy disguised
as scheduling)

Sixty days, Johnny. June first.
It's a Monday.

They go. The door closes.

Jonathan stands alone in the middle of the museum. The
percolator finishes in the kitchen -- its little dying
gurgle -- and the house ticks, and four thousand records
look down at him from the shelves, suddenly, all at once,
weighing what records weigh.

INSERT -- TITLE CARD, white on black, the film's first:
"60 DAYS"

INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- LIVING ROOM -- NIGHT

Jonathan, cross-legged on the floor with a legal pad. At
the top, block letters: "PLAN."

Under it, after some time: "1. Boxes."

Under that: nothing.

He looks at the shelves. Four thousand spines. Eleven
years of his life and fifty of Earl's, in order, by a
system only two men understood.

He picks up his phone. Thumb to MARCO -- the reflex of
twenty years, the person you narrate the disaster to, the
whole point of having a disaster --

The thread is still open from the car. The last messages
sit there: typed, deleted, nothing sent. A little column

of ghosts.

He puts the phone down.

And here is the shape of the second act, arriving in silence: the one real deadline of his life has landed, and the one person he'd talk it through with is gone, and both of those are his fault in ways his nine lanes can itemize perfectly and repair not at all.

He writes on the pad: "2."

Nothing after it.

INSERT -- TITLE CARD:

"51 DAYS"

INT. THE KING'S ARMS -- BAR -- NIGHT

Quiz night. Jonathan at the mic, laminated card in hand -- and something's off. He reads flat:

JONATHAN

Round two. Question four. What
year did --
 (he loses the line; finds
 it; loses it)
-- what year did the Everly
Brothers --

He stops. The room waits. Table Nine looks up from its phones.

JONATHAN (CONT'D)

 (quietly; off-format)
It was 1957. "Bye Bye Love." They
were kids from Kentucky, their
dad had a radio show, and the
song got rejected by thirty
artists before they --
 (beat; he looks at the card;
 he looks at the room; a man
 hearing himself)
Thirty artists heard it first and
passed. That's the -- nobody ever
asks about the thirty.

Silence in the fake-Tudor bar. Priya, at her table, watches him with the specific alertness of an ER nurse recognizing a presentation.

JONATHAN (CONT'D)
(recovering; laminate voice
back on)
Half a point for the year, half
for the title.

INT. THE KING'S ARMS -- BAR -- LATER

Jonathan packs the shoebox. Priya appears, coat on, no teasing in her tonight.

PRIYA
You okay? You did a thing up
there.

JONATHAN
I'm moving. Being moved. There's
a distinction and it's
load-bearing.

PRIYA
Where to?

JONATHAN
(the truth, arriving like a
diagnosis)
No idea. I have a Buick, four
thousand records, and fifty-one
days.
(beat; dry; the joke a
handrail)
Two of those are assets.

PRIYA
(shouldering her bag;
plainly)
My cousin still wants the demo,
you know. The podcast guy. That

offer didn't expire.
 (beat; and she says the next
 part carefully, because
 she's met him)
Most things expire, Loft. That
one hasn't yet. I'd move it up
the list.

She goes. Jonathan stands with the shoebox. Inside it,
under a sub-label, a business card continues to exist.

INSERT -- TITLE CARD:

"38 DAYS"

INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- LIVING ROOM -- DAY

The doorbell. Jonathan opens it to TERRENCE VAULT, 55,
linen jacket, silver ponytail, reading glasses on a chain
-- a record appraiser with the bedside manner of a hanging
judge. He carries a portable turntable like a doctor's
bag.

TERRENCE
 (stepping in; scanning the
 shelves before he's fully
 through the door; a low
 whistle)
Well. Hello, wall.

He walks the shelves. Pulls a spine at random. Examines
the sleeve edge. Pulls another. His face gives nothing.

TERRENCE (CONT'D)
Original owner?

JONATHAN
My grandfather. 1955 through
about '88, then he tapered. I've
kept them at forty-five to fifty
percent humidity, sleeved
everything in poly, the 45s are
--

TERRENCE

(cutting him off, not
unkindly, by putting on his
glasses)

Son, I've done four hundred of
these. Let me tell you what I
always tell the family, before
the hoping gets expensive.

(he holds up a record)

Condition is everything.

Sentiment is a storage problem.

He sets up the portable turntable on the console --
sacrilege; Jonathan visibly suppresses comment -- and
begins working through a crate. Drop needle, listen ten
seconds, lift, grade, next. Brutal. Efficient. A man
lifting needles mid-song, professionally, hundreds of
times a day.

Jonathan watches every lift like it's minor surgery being
performed on him without anesthetic.

TERRENCE (CONT'D)

(working; not looking up)

Common pressings, club editions,
reissues -- that's seventy
percent of any collection,
including this one. Dollar-bin. I
take those in bulk or you donate
them.

(lift; grade; next)

The middle third's worth real
money to the right store.

(he stops. Holds one 45 up
to the window light, tilted,
like a jeweler.)

And then every so often --

(he checks the label, the
matrix number etched in the
run-out; his voice changes
half a degree, which for
this man is a gasp)

-- where did he get this?

JONATHAN

(looking)

The Five Satins?

TERRENCE

First pressing on Standord.
Before Ember picked it up.
There's maybe -- MAYBE -- a few
hundred of these in the world in
this shape.

(he looks at Jonathan over
the glasses)

Church basement record. You know
the story?

JONATHAN

(quietly)

St. Bernadette's. New Haven. I
know the story.

TERRENCE

(setting it down with two
fingers, like evidence)

That one doesn't go in a crate
with the others. That one you
decide about on purpose.

He goes back to grading. Lift. Grade. Next. Jonathan picks
up the Standord 45 and holds it, both hands, the way you
hold the one thing in a burning building.

INSERT -- TITLE CARD:

"29 DAYS"

**INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- HALLWAY / GARAGE / KITCHEN -- SERIES
-- DAY/NIGHT**

The packing, in fragments, alone:

-- Jonathan wraps the Zenith console's knobs in bubble
wrap, each one individually, then sits on the floor next
to it for a while, doing nothing, in the museum he is
dismantling.

-- The estate sale lady, DARLENE, 60s, cheerfully tags
Earl's recliner with a sticker: \$40. Jonathan, from the
doorway, watches the sticker go on. Says nothing. Leaves

the room like it's a viewing.

-- Night. Jonathan eats a patty melt he made himself, standing over the sink, next to a full prescription bottle and the lab slip, still un-actioned, held to the fridge by a magnet shaped like Ohio for no reason anyone remembers.

-- He boxes records. Crate after crate. And notice: he's playing them while he packs -- one song per record, needle lifted mid-fade, sleeve, box, next. A man saying four thousand goodbyes and cutting every single one of them off before the end.

INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- LIVING ROOM -- NIGHT

Late. Jonathan, surrounded by half-filled crates, holds his phone. MARCO's thread. Twenty-six days of silence now.

He types: "Aunt Regina sold the house. 26 days. I keep starting to tell you things."

His thumb hovers over send.

HOLD on the hover -- one second, two, three --

He deletes it, letter by letter, all the way back to an empty field. The cursor blinks in the nothing.

Then, from the crate beside him, he takes the Standord 45 out of its sleeve. Looks at it a long time.

He crosses to the Zenith -- unwraps one bubble-wrapped knob, just the one -- sets the record down, needle in.

The church basement fills the emptying room. That echo. Jesus's actual house. The bass singer, down under everything, doo-doo-doo, holding the entire thing up, completely unthanked.

Jonathan sits on the floor against Earl's tagged recliner, in the museum with the lights half off, and listens.

And the song leans toward its ending --

-- and his hand starts to rise toward the tonearm, the reflex of a lifetime --

-- and he puts the hand back in his lap.

The song fades. All the way. The long slow honest fade, the sound of something knowing how to leave -- and then the run-out groove: click... click... click...

Jonathan sits in the click. Eyes shut. It is not peace.
It's rehearsal.

INSERT -- TITLE CARD:

"14 DAYS"

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- KITCHEN -- DAY

Jonathan at the kitchen table with a legal pad, and this time the pad is FULL. Pages of block print. But it's not the "PLAN" list.

INSERT -- LEGAL PAD, heading: "SECOND SIGN -- what I said / what I should have said."

Two columns. Left column: every brutal line from the demolition, quoted verbatim from his own flawless memory -- "margins don't work," "novelty print," "no size run above XL." Right column, across from each: work. Real work. "Pre-order model kills the unit cap -- see attached." "Novelty becomes signature if the story leads: SAINTS FOR SINNERS -- he already HAS the story, it's his grandmother's medallion, ASK HIM ABOUT IT." "Extended sizing is the market gap, not the flaw -- literally nobody serves it at this price point -- THIS IS THE WHOLE BUSINESS."

Page after page. The nine-lane mind, pointed the other way for the first time in its operational history. Demolition inspection as love letter.

He squares the pages. Staples them. Then he takes a pen and writes across the top of page one -- and we see him almost write something clever, the pen hovering, the eternal draft -- and instead he writes, plainly:

INSERT -- PAGE ONE, handwritten: "You didn't ask for this either. But it's the other half of what I owed you. -- J."

INT. MARCO'S APARTMENT BUILDING -- HALLWAY -- DAY

Jonathan stands at Marco's door with the stapled pages in a manila envelope. He raises his hand to knock.

Doesn't.

Stands there. Through the door, faintly: the sewing machine, running. Stopping. Running.

He crouches, slides the envelope under the door, and leaves -- fast, before it can be handed back, the coward's exit and the only possible one, and the film does not judge him for it, because under that door is more than he has ever put through any opening in his life.

EXT. MARCO'S APARTMENT BUILDING -- STREET -- CONTINUOUS

Jonathan walks to the Buick. Behind him, up in the building, the sewing machine stops.

He doesn't look back. He drives.

INSERT -- TITLE CARD:

"9 DAYS"

INT. DMV -- VAN NUYS -- DAY

The DMV. Final boss of the mundane. Jonathan enters -- and we brace for the heist score, the tactical breathing, the folder of talking points --

-- and instead: he takes a number. Sits. Waits. Reads the Didion-thick estate paperwork in his lap like a normal citizen. His number is called. He approaches the window.

DMV CLERK

(monotone)

Purpose of visit.

JONATHAN

Change of address.

DMV CLERK

New address?

JONATHAN
(beat; and he reads it off a
lease -- a real lease, his
first in eleven years,
folded in the paperwork)
1122 Hazeltine. Apartment C. Van
Nuys.

The clerk types. Stamps. Slides a form. Done.

JONATHAN (CONT'D)
(to the clerk; almost
disappointed)
That's it?

DMV CLERK
(already looking past him)
That's it. Next.

EXT. DMV -- PARKING LOT -- CONTINUOUS

Jonathan walks to the Buick, checks his watch, and stops
dead.

JONATHAN
(to no one; genuinely
shaken)
Eleven minutes.

He looks back at the DMV -- the fortress, the myth, the
twenty-year dragon -- just a beige building full of tired
people, eleven minutes deep.

He gets in the car. Sits a moment.

JONATHAN (CONT'D)
(quietly; to the rearview;
the closest this film will
ever come to a thesis, and
he throws it away like a
receipt)
Huh.

INSERT -- TITLE CARD:

"3 DAYS"

INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- LIVING ROOM -- DAY

Nearly empty. The shelves bare. The crates gone to Terrence and the record stores -- all but ONE crate, by the door, hand-labeled: "KEEPERS." Maybe sixty records. Chosen on purpose.

The recliner's gone -- sold, \$40. The rectangle of unfaded carpet where it sat. This film's ghost-geometry.

The Zenith console remains, wrapped, an island. Darlene the estate sale lady checks her clipboard.

DARLENE

Console's the last big piece. I
got a dealer coming Saturday,
he'll flip it to a bar in Silver
Lake, they'll put succulents on
it.

Jonathan looks at the Zenith. Succulents.

JONATHAN

It's not for sale.

DARLENE

It's on my sheet.

JONATHAN

It's off your sheet. It's --
(and he says the next words
as a man finalizing
something)
-- it's spoken for.

EXT. DOTTIE'S HOUSE -- NEXT DOOR -- DAY

DOTTIE KWAN, 78 -- the neighbor, the buyer, Earl's chess opponent of thirty years -- watches from her porch as Jonathan and a grunting GERRY (knee brace and all) wheel the Zenith console up her walk on a dolly.

DOTTIE

(deadpan; not moving to
help)

I bought the house, not the
furniture.

JONATHAN

It's not furniture. It's
infrastructure.

(setting it down on her
porch; catching his breath;
and then, the actual
sentence, gruff, fast,
before it can be inspected
and killed)

He'd want it hearing the same
walls. It shouldn't have to move
twice.

Dottie looks at the console. At Jonathan. Thirty years of
chess reads the whole board in one pass.

DOTTIE

(turning back inside; over
her shoulder)

Leave the records for it. The
ones he cheated at chess to. He'd
hum them so I'd lose count of
moves. Fats Domino. The cheater's
soundtrack.

JONATHAN

(a beat; then, helpless, the
reflex firing one last time
-- but pointed, note, at
generosity now)

"Blueberry Hill," "Ain't That a
Shame," or "I'm Walkin'"? Because
tempo-wise, for cheating purposes
--

DOTTIE

(door closing behind her)

All three, obviously.

INSERT -- TITLE CARD:

"MOVING DAY"

INT. EARL'S HOUSE -- EMPTY -- MORNING

Empty-empty. Every room a rectangle of light and outlet covers. Jonathan walks it once, alone -- the long walk every one of these films owes its house -- hallway, kitchen (percolator gone), living room.

At the living room window he stops. Outside, at the curb: the Buick, packed. One crate of KEEPERS riding shotgun, seat-belted in. Actually seat-belted.

He takes Earl's photo off the wall last -- the final object -- and looks at it. The permanent squint. The eternal off-camera joke.

JONATHAN

(to the photo; the last
conversation in the museum)

A real song should know how to
leave.

He tucks the photo under his arm. Reaches for the light switch out of eleven years of habit -- the power's already off. Nothing to switch. He does it anyway. Click.

EXT. EARL'S HOUSE -- CURB -- CONTINUOUS

Jonathan loads the photo, closes the trunk -- and stops.

Leaning against the Buick's passenger door: a garment bag. Black. Zipped. A note pinned to it.

He looks around. The street is empty. Up at Dottie's -- her curtain doesn't move, which with Dottie could mean anything.

He unpins the note.

INSERT -- NOTE, handwritten, no salutation: "Read your homework. Some of it was even right. The pre-order thing worked -- 41 units, don't let it go to your head. This is sample #1 of the extended run. It's a 2XL because I know what you actually wear, not what you tell Val. -- M. //

P.S. The Tower card meant the house, you enormous idiot.
The app knew in March."

Jonathan unzips the bag.

Inside: a camp shirt. Generous cut. The medallion print -- saints and small gold signs on deep blue, and worked into the pattern, unmistakable if you know what you're looking at, tiny and repeating: a 45 RPM record adapter. The little plastic spider. Woven in among the saints.

Jonathan stands at the curb holding a shirt that forgives him.

He looks up the street. Nothing. He looks at his phone. Nothing new.

He puts the shirt on. Right there, over his T-shirt, at the curb of his emptied life. It fits. Of course it fits. It was always going to fit; that was the whole thesis of the brand.

He types, one thumb: "The adapter in the print. Nobody else will ever notice it."

A moment. Then the reply bubble. Then:

INSERT -- PHONE, from MARCO: "Nobody else is supposed to. Diner music, cuz."

And then, before Jonathan can compose eleven drafts of the perfect reply:

INSERT -- PHONE, from MARCO: "Val's. Tuesday. You're buying. Bring the sales pitch for the podcast, I've decided you're doing it."

Jonathan looks at the phone. Types: "The podcast space is saturated"

Looks at it.

Deletes it, letter by letter.

Types: "Tuesday."

Sends it.

INT. APARTMENT C -- HAZELTINE AVENUE -- EVENING

Small. White walls. Boxes. A folding chair. A man's whole life at 44, reduced to a rentable rectangle -- and the

film refuses to make it tragic, because look:

On a milk crate in the corner: a cheap new turntable,
already set up. First thing unpacked. Priorities.

Jonathan, still in the shirt, kneels at the KEEPERS crate.
Flips -- past the Standard 45 in its place of honor -- and
pulls something out. Sets it on the platter.

He also sets his phone on the milk crate, propped against
the wall. Opens the voice memo app. Looks at the red
record button for a long moment.

Presses it.

JONATHAN

(to the phone; to the room;
to nobody; take one)

Okay. Ten minutes.

(beat)

In 1956, five kids from New Haven
couldn't afford a studio, so they
went down into the basement of a
church called St. Bernadette's --

He drops the needle. The song comes in under his voice --
that echo, that basement, that bass line down under
everything, holding the whole thing up --

-- and Jonathan talks, and the song plays, and the boxes
sit unpacked, and the folding chair waits, and for the
first time in the entire film a great idea of Jonathan
Loft's is allowed to keep breathing past its first sixty
seconds.

We drift back, out of the room, down the hallway of the
ordinary building, his voice getting smaller, the song
getting smaller --

And we stay on the shut door of Apartment C, and listen,
as the song plays all the way to the end.

And then the click... click... click... of the run-out
groove.

And under it, his voice, still going.

FADE OUT.

THE END